

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

**Two flower-shaped silver pieces, their simple and elegant** central design speckled with lapis lazuli blue—the gulabi meenakari cufflinks and a matching brooch, the latter with a peacock motif, were chosen with care before Prime Minister Narendra Modi gifted them to US President Joe Biden and US first lady Jill Biden at the G-7 summit in Germany in late June. Then there were the pieces of black pottery, polished to a subdued gleam and looking as distinguished as objets d'art from the palace of an ancient potentate. The recipient was Japanese PM Fumio Kishida. Others leaders like French president Emmanuel Macron, Italian premier Mario Draghi and German chancellor Olaf Scholz got ornate zari zardozi embroidered boxes, marble inlay table tops and handmade tea sets. The golden thread that stitches these treasures together is that they were all created exclusively by Uttar Pradesh's artisans, working under Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath's ambitious programme to revive traditional craft—the ODOP (One District One Product) scheme. It has not only given a fillip to neglected crafts, the scheme has also set the tone for a steady increase in exports from UP. It comes under the MSME (micro, small and medium enterprises) department.

All this activity has seen UP's exports increase by a whopping 80 per cent in value in the past five years. Traditionally-made ODOP products have played a leading role—70 per cent of the products exported from the state come under its ambit, according to state government information. In 2017-18, the value of UP's exports was Rs 88,967.4 crore; it is Rs 1,56, 897.2 crore for 2021-22. Even during the pandemic, the state's exports saw a rise of 30 per cent, largely driven by (both the online and offline) sale of ODOP products. The scheme, started in 2018, has not only protected the livelihood of artisans, but also gave them the reason and belief to revive traditional crafts that were nearing extinction. It also stopped many of their practitioners from migrating to other states.

Sohit Prajapati, a 42-year-old black pottery artisan based in Azamgarh who earlier sold bhel-puri in Mumbai, returned in 2017 to his wheel. At one stage, Sohit contemplated a move back to Mumbai, but stayed on when demand for his ware, and profits, shot up after he registered with the ODOP scheme. Under it, Sohit got financial aid and help in selling his products on national and international platforms. Sohit says his income has tripled in the past four years. Nowadays, he has orders from several countries, including the US and UAE. In Azamgarh's Nizamabad town, over 200 artisans are now engaged in making black pottery. Their numbers had dwindled to 20 before the ODOP scheme took effect.

## *THE TURNING POINT*

Manoj Vishwakarma, a 36-year-old Varanasi-based sixth-generation gulabi meenakari—a GI-tagged art form—artisan tells INDIA TODAY that after seeing many fellow artisans quitting, he almost decided to follow suit. From a nadir in 2018, when gulabi meenakari work almost ground to a halt in Varanasi, the turnaround in the lives of artistes like Vishwakarma was miraculous. Here, too, the credit goes to ODOP. Vishwakarma's business just took off after he got financial aid and guidance from experts through ODOP. "Earlier, we used to do gulabi meenakari on products like hand-made peacocks, and idols of gods. Through experts, we got to know how to fashion cufflinks," he says with pride.

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The ODOP scheme was launched by Yogi Adityanath on January 24, 2018 to make product-specific traditional hubs in each of UP's 75 districts. Its objective is the protection, growth and revival of local handicraft and expertise, thus preventing migration to urban centres because of the lack of employment. In all, 62 traditional crafts were identified.

According to Navneet Sehgal, additional chief secretary, MSME, "ODOP is reviving traditional handicraft and has helped increase the state's exports. We have the largest number of MSMEs in the country, the majority in the unorganised sector." Sehgal adds that whether it is